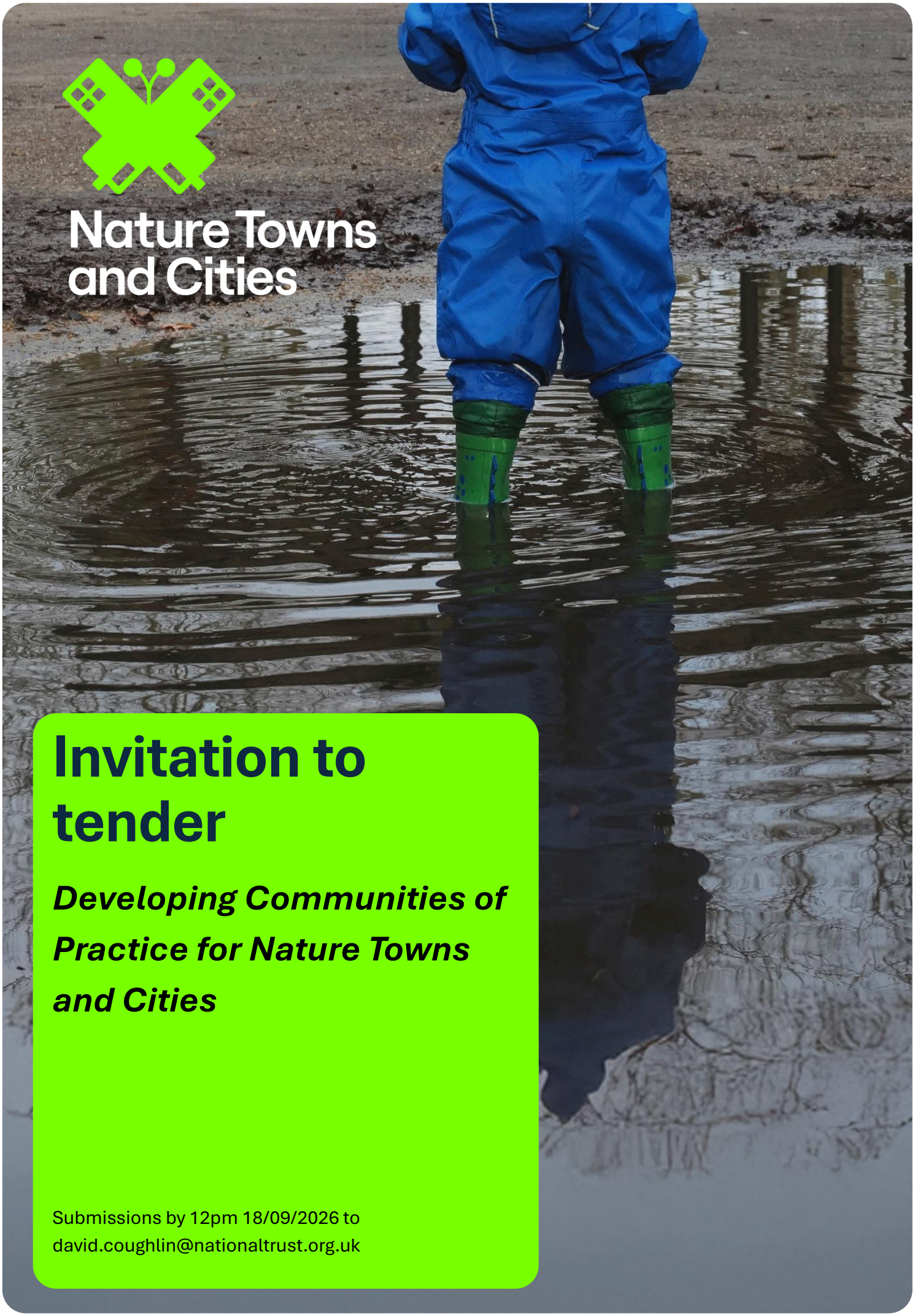


Nature Towns and Cities

Invitation to tender

Developing Communities of Practice for Nature Towns and Cities

Submissions by 12pm 18/09/2026 to david.coughlin@nationaltrust.org.uk

Communities of practice Invitation to Tender

Context and overview

Nature Towns and Cities is a UK-wide mission to bring nature and green space to urban areas for everyone's benefit. It is backed by coalition of public, private and third sector organisations committed to putting accessible nature at the heart of vibrant, healthy, resilient places and communities, focusing on those areas that will benefit the most. Over the next 10 years we're aiming to help 5 million more people enjoy better access to green and blue space close to home, and 1 million more children to be able to play in nature on their doorstep.

To do this we have three main area of activity:

- Weaving nature and nature-based solutions info the urban fabric; putting it at the centre of future plans and place-making across a whole town or city. Working with local councils and place-based partnerships.
- Empowering communities to lead change in their neighbourhood, helping to put nature at the heart of local communities.
- Mobilising funding and finance for nature, with a target of £1billion mobilised by 2035. This requires funding and finance innovation to create new products, mechanisms and markets for urban nature and a programme of investment readiness.

By 2035 we are aiming to support 100 towns and cities and 1000 communities.

To support places and communities on their journey we have already provided training, peer mentoring, action learning, case studies and how to guides, conferences and events and informal opportunities to collaborate, though the Nature Towns and Cities Network. We now wish to develop and establish a small number of Communities of Practice to connect people and organisations working to create, improve and care for urban nature across the UK. These spaces will connect local government and wider public sector, national NGOs, VCSE organisations and possibly private sector organisations around shared ambitions for greener, fairer, healthier towns and cities.

Communities of Practice is a working concept, intended to start coalescing the large Nature Towns and Cities network around purposeful activity on specific themes. We know from extensive engagement with local government and community organisations, our own interim evaluation, and feedback from past events that there is an appetite for facilitated spaces for peer learning, where participation is action-oriented. We want to create spaces where network members can work through live challenges, share experience, learn from different perspectives and identify practical next steps. This commission will determine what these spaces look and feel like, and how they are

delivered. Critically, we know we are not looking for taught courses, formal CPD or informal networking.

Community of Practice

As mentioned above, Communities of Practice is a working title for a set of collaborative spaces that will form part of the Nature Towns and Cities Network. They will provide structured, ongoing peer-learning not provided by the existing features of the network:

- Inspiration events (one-off, online, public, focussing on a specific theme)
- Group learning (time-bound, small group, class format, focussing on key capabilities for change)
- Mentoring (1:1 peer mentoring organised between local authority staff, limited audience)
- Site visits (showcase successful project delivery, limited audience due to cost)

Communities of Practice aims:

Create and improve connection

Connect people across sectors, disciplines, geographies and types of organisations to break down silos and share experience. Communities of Practice must be relevant and engaging for local government and the third sector.

Act as engines for change

Support participants to tackle problems in new and better ways, share leading practice, develop ideas, and apply learning in their own places and organisational contexts.

Grow the Nature Towns and Cities movement and initiative

Deepen engagement and trust across a wider network of places and organisations, strengthen the collective voice of Nature Towns and Cities. Expand the pool of organisations ready for future opportunities such as future capacity building grants, those participating in the Nature Towns and Cities accreditation, funded accelerator cohorts or more intensive support.

Provide practical value for participants

Help participants move from ambition to action. Or increase and enhance existing implementation.

Generate insight for Nature Towns and Cities

Surface stories of impact, emerging practice and opportunities for resources.

Scope

This commission will span the early stages of design for the Communities of Practice, through to planning and support for the initial phase of delivery. This is split into two tasks that may run concurrently:

1. Early Design

Design a clear and practical delivery plan for Nature Towns and Cities' Communities of Practice, including:

- What format(s) could best meet the aims above?
- Purpose, principles and participant experience – what is the USP of Communities of Practice, does it address a gap in the market of existing support for local authorities and VCSE organisations?
- Appropriate facilitation models and techniques, taking into account the cross-sector audience of local government and VCSE sector. How can we create an inclusive space that addresses existing power imbalances?
- Identify three to five priority themes for delivery, taking into account existing knowledge, partnerships, momentum and audience interest.
- How themes relate to cross-cutting issues and contribute to systems change in different areas (e.g. finance, participation, stewardship, political engagement, delivery models and long-term management).
- Recommended group size, frequency, attendance requirements, session length and rhythm.
- Recommendation on how we go about recruitment and offering places on the Communities of Practice.
- How open or structured the communities should be, considering the best way to build trust and momentum.
- How insights and support needs are fed back into Nature Towns and Cities.

2. Facilitation design and support

The role of the consultant at this stage will be to develop delivery plans and facilitation models and to facilitate the Communities of Practice for the first 3-6 months (depending on frequency) supported by Nature Towns and Cities partner organisations and subject matter experts. Nature Towns and Cities will broker the input of subject matter experts. The delivery plans and facilitation models should meet the aims stated above and ensure consistency across the 3-5 Communities of Practice. This should include:

- Methods for surfacing live challenges
- Approaches for peer problem-solving such as action learning, appreciative inquiry, structured reflection
- A structure that balances expert input with participant-led discussion
- An approach that prioritises equity, by addressing power dynamics within the group, and bringing in voices of people with lived experience

Budget and indicative timeline

The budget for this work is £50,000 inc VAT

Invitation to tender live	**25 August 2026**	
Tender deadline	**12pm 18 September 2026**	
Appoint consultants	**September 2026**	
Design	**October-November 2026**	Review aims and draft operating model. Refine themes, design session formats, agree invite list.
Recruit	**December**	Publicise through Nature Towns and Cities network and comms channels.
Launch	**January and February 2027**	Facilitate initial sessions

Submission process

Tender responses should be sent to david.coughlin@nationaltrust.org.uk and include details of the following:

- Outline of your proposed approach, including outputs
- Description of your relevant experience, including examples of at least two pieces of similar work you have carried out.
- Project timeline or Gantt chart
- Key responsibilities of team members and time allocations
- Proposed budget breakdown
- Answers to the mandatory questions and company information included at Annex 2.

Proposals should not exceed 8 pages in length (this limit does not include your answers to the mandatory questions), individual CVs are not required.

Should the principal contractor propose subcontracting any elements of the delivery of this process this should be made clear in their proposal. Applications from consortia are welcome.

Annex: Mandatory questions

Section 1 - Mandatory Questions		
Please provide your response to each of the questions below. All questions in this section are mandatory and are to be considered as **Pass** or **Fail** questions. Should you submit a Response without being able to meet the mandatory requirements, your tender submission may not be evaluated any further. It is advisable that you read the mandatory questions first, to ensure that you can answer satisfactorily, as this will prevent any time being wasted by all parties concerned.		
Question number	Question	Response
1.1	Within the past five years, has your organisation (or any member of your proposed consortium, if applicable), Directors or partner or any other person who has powers of representation, decision or control been convicted of or are aware of any ongoing criminal investigations or charges relating any of the following offences? a) conspiracy b) corruption c) bribery d) fraud e) any offence listed-(i) in section 41 of the Counter Terrorism Act 2008, (ii) in Schedule 2 to that Act where the court has determined that there is a terrorist connection; f) any offence under sections 44 to 46 of the Serious Crime Act 2007 which relates to an offence covered by the previous two points g) money laundering; h) an offence in connection with the proceeds of criminal conduct; (i) an offence under section 4 of the Asylum and Immigration Act 2004; (ii) an offence under sections 57 to 59A of the Sexual Offences Act 2003; (iii) an offence under sections 70 to 71 of the Coroners and Justice Act 2009; (iv) an offence in connection with the proceeds of drug trafficking;	Yes ☐ No ☐

	i) an offence under the Modern Slavery Act 2015 or charges relating to Modern Slavery in any area of its supply chain? If you have answered “yes” please provide full details including, but not limited to: • the date of conviction • which of the grounds listed the conviction was for • the reason for conviction • the identity of who has been convicted. You should also describe any corrective action you may have undertaken to date or any planned corrective action still to be taken, including timescales. The information provided will be assessed by the Trust and used to determine whether a Pass or Fail should be applied to this question.	
1.2	Have any of your organisation’s tax returns submitted on or after 1 October 2012; a) Given rise to a criminal conviction for tax related offences which is unspent, or to a civil penalty for fraud or evasion; or b) Been found to be incorrect as a result of: i. HMRC successfully challenging your organisation under the General Anti-Abuse Rule (GAAR) or the "Halifax" abuse principle; or ii. a tax authority in a jurisdiction in which the legal entity is established successfully challenging it under any tax rules or legislation that have an effect equivalent or similar to the GAAR or the "Halifax" abuse principle; or iii. the failure of an avoidance scheme in which your organisation was involved and which was, or should have been, notified under the Disclosure of Tax Avoidance Scheme (DOTAS) or any	Yes ☐ No ☐

	equivalent or similar regime in a jurisdiction in which your organisation is established. If you have answered "yes" please provide full details including, but not limited to: • Corrective action undertaken to date, • Planned corrective action to be taken, • Changes in personnel or ownership since the Occasion of Non-Compliance (OONC), or • Changes in financial, accounting, audit or management procedures since the OONC. The information provided will be assessed by the Trust and used to determine whether a Pass or Fail should be applied to this question.	
1.3	Within the past five years has it been established by a judicial or administrative decision having final and binding effect in accordance with the legal provisions of any part of the United Kingdom or the legal provisions of the country in which your organisation is established (if outside the UK), that your organisation is in breach of obligations related to the payment of tax or social security contributions? If "yes", please provide further details. Please confirm whether you have paid or have entered into a binding arrangement with a view to paying. The information provided will be assessed by the Trust and used to determine whether a Pass or Fail should be applied to this question.	Yes ☐ No ☐
1.4	If you are a commercial organisation with a minimum financial turnover of £36M, please confirm that you are compliant with Section 54 (Transparency in Supply Chains) of the Modern Slavery Act 2015.	**(a)** **N/A** – our turnover is less than £36M - **Note**: selecting option (a) will require further information on what steps the organisation has taken during the current financial year to ensure that slavery and

	Please delete all options that do not apply.	human trafficking is not taking place in any of its supply chains or own business. **(b) Yes** - Please provide the latest copy of, or link to, your Modern Slavery Statement. **(c) No** – we are not compliant but will be prior to commencement of a contract. (Please provide details on how you would achieve this). **(d) No** – we are not and will not be compliant at the time of award of the contract – **Note**: selecting option (d) will result in a Fail for this question and you bid will not be evaluated any further.
1.5	In the past five years, has your organisation (or any member of your proposed consortium, if applicable), its Directors, partners, or any individual with powers of representation, decision-making, or control been convicted of, or are they currently under investigation or facing charges related to any of the following offences? a) a finding of unlawful discrimination by an Employment Tribunal, an Employment Appeal Tribunal or any other court or tribunal (or in comparable proceedings in jurisdiction other than the UK). b) following formal investigation by the Equality and Human Rights Commission or its predecessors (or a comparable body in a jurisdiction other than the UK), a complaint of unlawful discrimination has been upheld c) a finding of unlawful discrimination against anyone with protected characteristics has been made against	Yes ☐ No ☐

	your organisation by any civil or criminal court (or a comparable body in a jurisdiction other than the UK). If you have answered "yes" please provide full details including, but not limited to: • the date of conviction • which of the grounds listed the conviction was for • the reason for conviction • the identity of who has been convicted. You should also describe any corrective action you may have undertaken to date or any planned corrective action still to be taken, including timescales. The information provided will be assessed by the Trust and used to determine whether a Pass or Fail should be applied to this question.	
1.6	Has any of the following situations occurred within your organisation in the past five years, or are any of the following situations currently applicable to your organisation? a) your organisation has violated obligations in the fields of environmental, social and labour law; b) your organisation is bankrupt or is the subject of insolvency or winding-up proceedings; c) your organisation is guilty of grave professional misconduct, which renders its integrity questionable; d) your organisation has entered into agreements with other economic operators aimed at distorting competition; e) the prior involvement of your organisation in the preparation of the procurement procedure has resulted in a distortion of competition which cannot be remedied; f) your organisation has shown significant or persistent deficiencies in the performance of a substantive requirement under a prior	Yes ☐ No ☐

	contract which led to early termination of that prior contract, damages or other comparable sanctions; g) your organisation has been guilty of serious misrepresentation in supplying information during a procurement exercise, or has withheld such information or is not able to submit the supporting documentation; or h) your organisation has attempted to unduly influence the decision-making process of the Trust, or to obtain confidential information; or has negligently provided misleading information that may have a material influence on decisions concerning exclusion, selection or award. If you have answered "yes" please provide full details outlining the circumstances and any actions you have since taken to put matters right, including, but not limited to: • the date of conviction • which of the grounds listed the conviction was for • the reason for conviction • the identity of who has been convicted. You should also describe any corrective action you may have undertaken to date or any planned corrective action still to be taken, including timescales. The information provided will be assessed by the Trust and used to determine whether a Pass or Fail should be applied to this question.	
1.7	Are you (if an individual) or any of your directors, partners, shareholders, owners, officers, employees, agents or associates (if an organisation) related or connected to any elected officials of the buyer or any officers of the buyer involved in the procurement?	Yes ☐ No ☐

	If "yes", please provide further details. This will not exclude you from being considered for this Opportunity, provided that you declare the relationship here so that the Trust can effectively mitigate the potential conflict of interest.	
1.8	Are there any actual or potential direct or indirect financial conflicts as described in Inducements and Competitive Tenders, which might arise for you if your organisation were to be awarded the contract, (including, where your organisation is a joint venture or consortium, or a member of a joint venture or consortium). If “yes” please provide details, including how you would ensure that the stated situation does not affect the value for money provided to the Trust.	Yes ☐ No ☐
1.9	Have you, or has your organisation been found to have employed the practice of ‘blacklisting’ in the last three years? If “yes”, please provide further details here, outlining the circumstances, and any actions you have since taken to put matters right.	Yes ☐ No ☐
1.10	Please confirm that your organisation complies with the UK General Data Protection Act 2018 and provide a copy/link to your Privacy Policy.	Yes ☐ No ☐

1.11	Please give confirmation that you have or if successful, will obtain the following minimum levels of insurance. **Note: Copies of your Insurance Certificates will be requested as part of the final due diligence, prior to the contract commencing.** If you are a member of Constructionline you do not need to provide copies of insurance certificates but will be asked to share details of your Constructionline membership so that we can confirm the levels of insurance held.	**Please select one box for each**	
		(a) Public Liability Insurance with a reputable insurer with a minimum indemnity level of £5,000,000.00 (five million pounds) for each and every claim and in place for a minimum of 3 years following contract completion;	Yes ☐ No ☐
		(b) Professional Indemnity Insurance with a reputable insurer with a minimum indemnity level of £1,000,000.00 (one million pounds) for each and every claim and in place for a minimum of 5 years following contract completion; and	Yes ☐ No ☐
		(c) Employers Liability Insurance with a reputable insurer with a minimum indemnity level of	Yes ☐ No ☐

		£5,000,000.00 (five million pounds) for each and every claim.	
		(d) **Product Liability Insurance** with a reputable insurer with a minimum indemnity level of £5,000,000.00 (five million pounds) for each and every claim.	Yes ☐ No ☐
1.12	All National Trust suppliers are required to register on the supplier database 'Proactis' providing company address and bank account details to enable prompt payment of invoices. There is no charge to register. Please confirm your willingness to register on Proactis is you are awarded this contract.	Yes ☐ No ☐	
1.13	The terms and conditions of contract that will govern any contract awarded as a result of this process are contained in Appendix A. Please confirm your acceptance of them or specify any queries you may have with them below.	Yes ☐ No ☐	

Section 2 - Company registration and address information

Please provide your response to each of the questions below.

All questions in this section are for information purposes only and will not form part of the evaluation.

Question number	Question	Response
2.1	Please provide details on your company structure, including: a) Company legal name b) Trading name if different to legal name c) Operating address and key contact details d) Registered office address and company registration number e) Date of incorporation f) Any parent or subsidiary companies g) Details of the Business Owners/Board Directors	
2.2	Is your organisation an intermediary company, as defined by IR35? If "yes", please give details.	Yes ☐ No ☐
2.3	Please confirm the contact details of the person responsible for queries relating to this RFP1.	